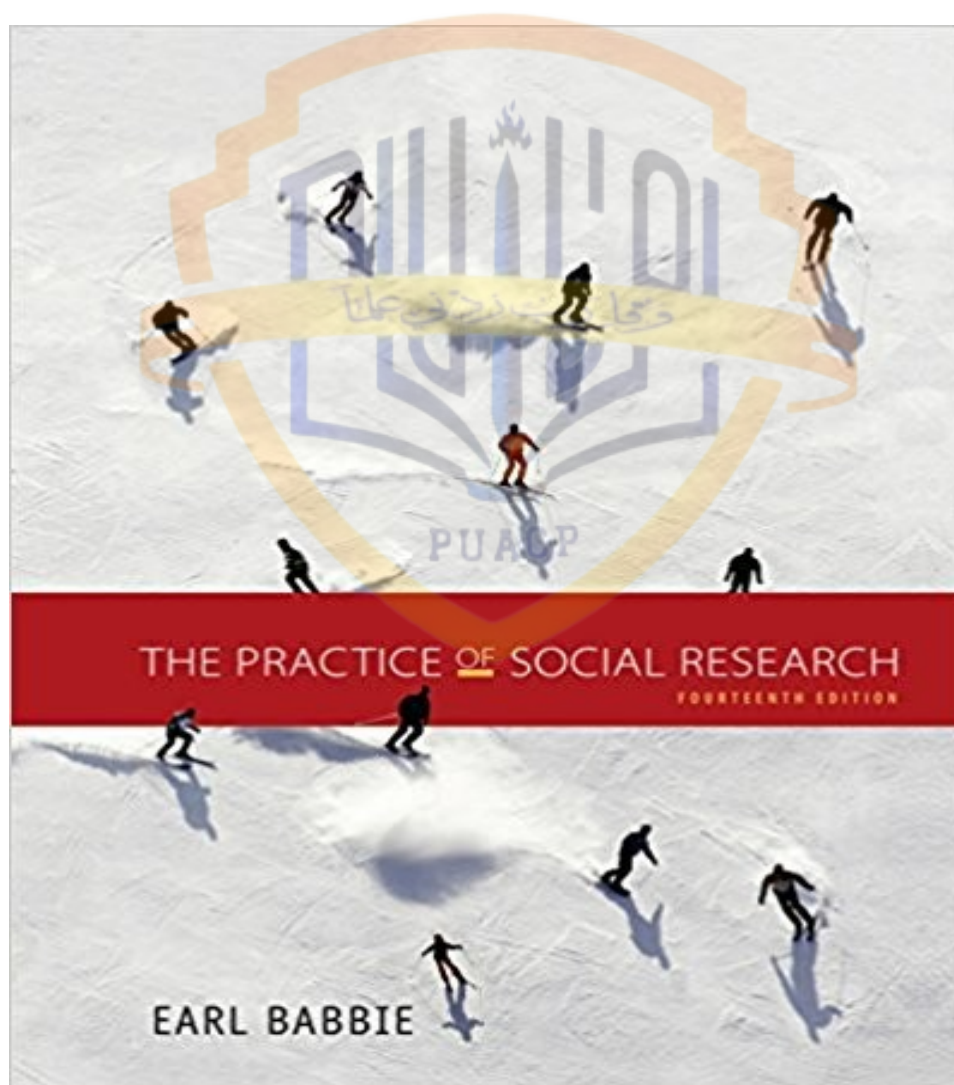


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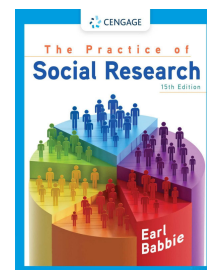
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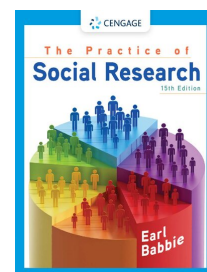
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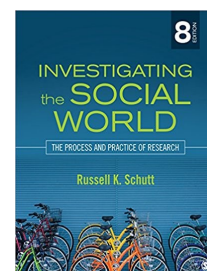
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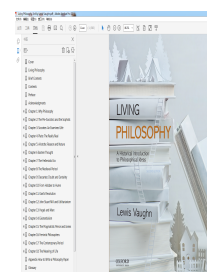
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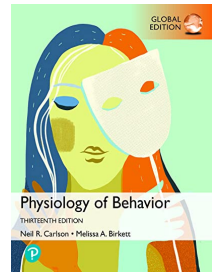
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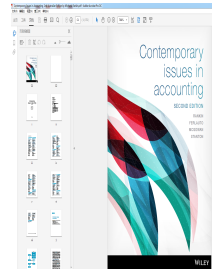
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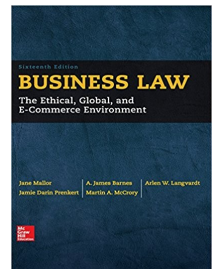
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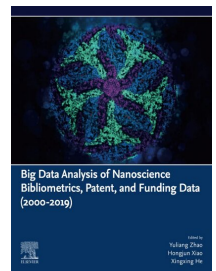
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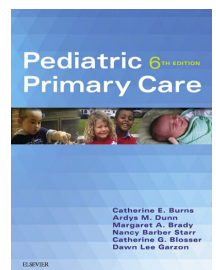
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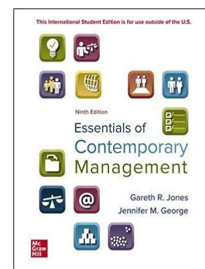
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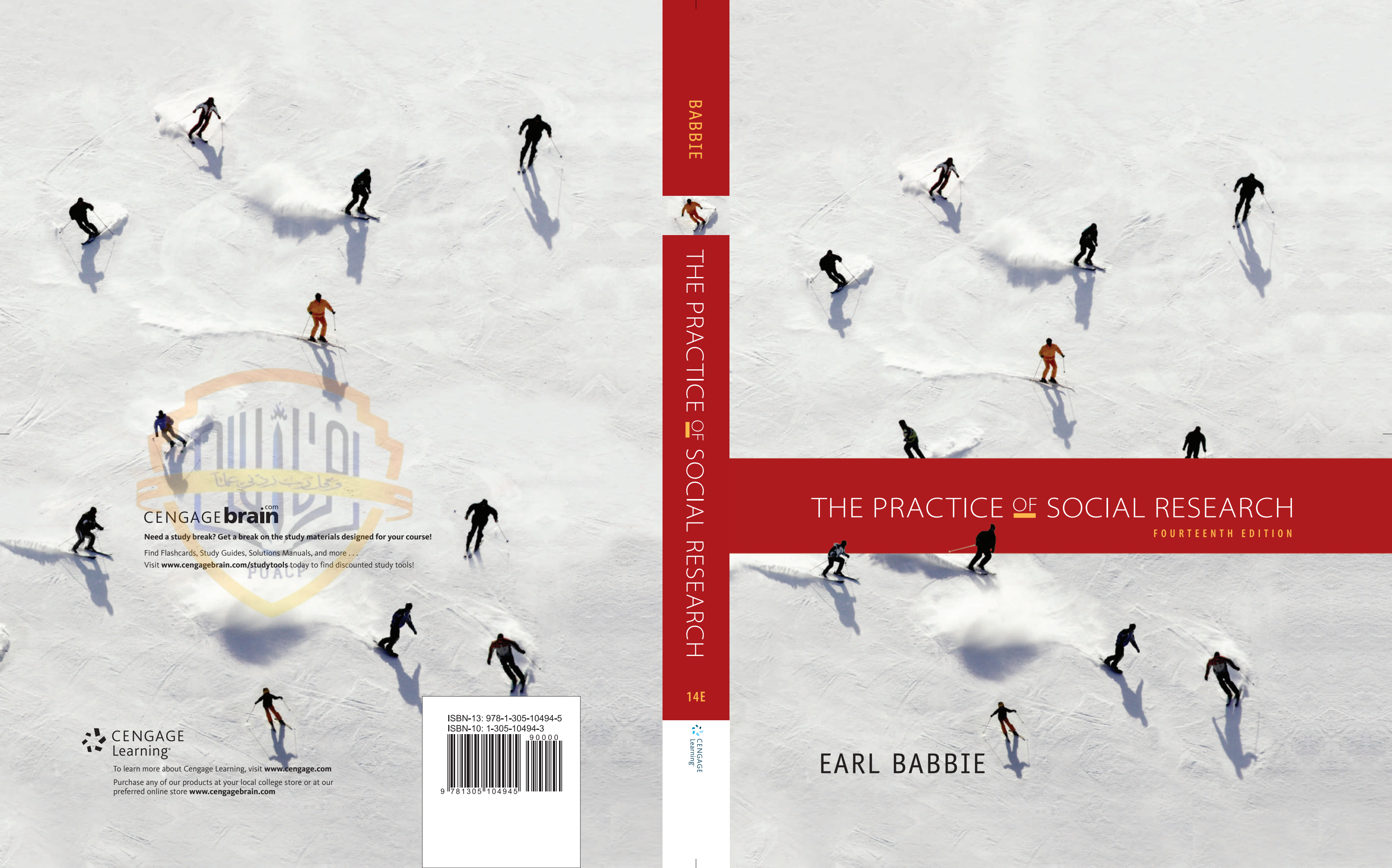


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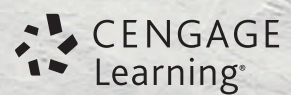


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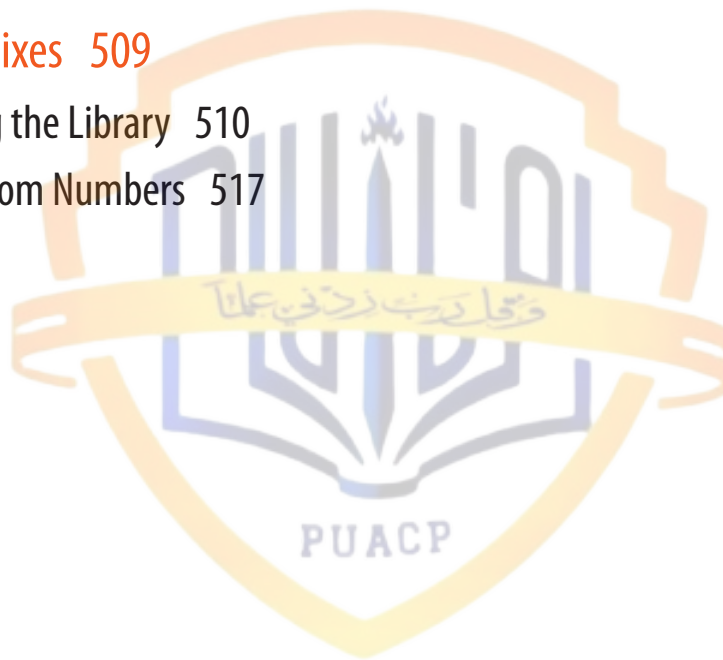
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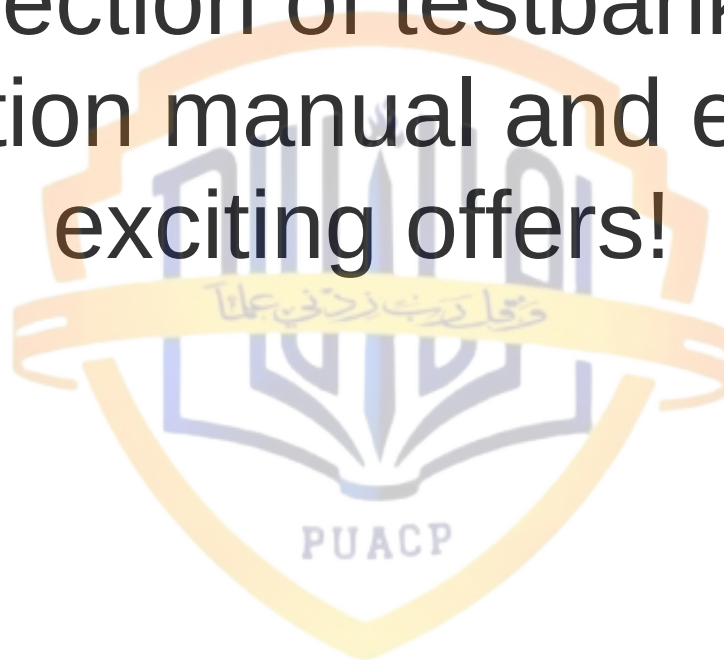
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Preface

A “few” years ago (I hate to tell you how many), I began teaching my first course in social research methods. The course focused specifically on survey research methods, and I had only six students in the class. As the semester progressed, I became more relaxed as a teacher. Before long, my students and I began meeting in my office, where I could grab and lend books from my own library as their relevance occurred to me during class meetings.

One nagging problem I faced then was the lack of a good textbook on survey research. The available books fell into one of two groups. Some books presented the theoretical logic of research methods in such abstract terms that I didn’t think students would be able to apply any of the general principles to the practical world of “doing” research. The other books were just the opposite. Often termed “cookbooks,” they presented detailed, step-by-step instructions on how to conduct a survey. Unfortunately, this approach only prepared students to conduct surveys very much like the ones described by the authors. Neither the abstract nor the “cookbook” approach seemed truly useful to students or their instructors.

One day I found myself jotting down the table of contents for my ideal research methods textbook. It was organized around three themes:

1. Understanding the theoretical principles on which scientific research is based;
2. Seeing how those principles are reflected in the established techniques for doing research;
3. Being prepared to make appropriate compromises whenever field conditions do not

permit the routine application of established techniques.

The next day, unexpectedly, Wadsworth called and asked me to write a methods text!

Survey Research Methods was published in 1973. My editors and I immediately received some good news, some bad news, and some additional good news. The first good news was that all survey research instructors seemed to love the book, and it was being used in virtually every survey research course in the country. The bad news was that there weren’t all that many survey research courses.

The final good news, however, was that many instructors who taught general social research courses—covering survey research alongside other research methods—were inclined to use our book and supplement it with other books dealing with field research, experiments, and so on. While adjusting to our specialized book, however, many instructors suggested that Wadsworth have “that same guy” write a more general social research text.

The preface of the first edition of *The Practice of Social Research* (1975) acknowledged the assistance of a dozen social research instructors from California to Florida. The book was a collaboration in a very real sense, even though only my name was on the cover and I was ultimately responsible for it.

The Practice of Social Research was an immediate success. Although it was initially written for sociology courses, subsequent editions have been increasingly used in fields such as psychology, public administration, urban studies, education, communications, social sciences, and political

science—in some 30 different disciplines, I’m told. Moreover, it’s being used by teachers and researchers in numerous countries around the world, and in 2000 a Beijing publisher released a two-volume Chinese edition.

I’ve laid out this lengthy history of the book for a couple of reasons. First, when I was a student, I suppose I thought of textbooks the same way that I thought about government buildings: They were just there. I never really thought about them as being written by human beings. I certainly never thought about textbooks as evolving: being updated, getting better, having errors corrected. As a student, I would have been horrified by the thought that any of my textbooks might contain mistakes!

Second, pointing out the evolution of the book sets the stage for a preview of the changes that have gone into this 14th edition. As with previous revisions, several factors have prompted changes. For example, because social research technology and practices are continually changing, the book must be updated to remain current and useful. In my own teaching, I frequently find improved ways to present standard materials. Colleagues also often share their ideas for ways to teach specific topics. Some of these appear as boxed inserts in the book. Both students and instructors often suggest that various topics be reorganized, expanded, clarified, shrunk, or—gasp—deleted.

New to the 14th Edition

In an earlier edition of this book, I said, “Revising a textbook such as this is a humbling experience. No matter how good it seems to be, there is no end of ideas about how it could be improved.” That observation still holds true. When we asked instructors what could be improved, they once again thought of things, and I’ve considered all their suggestions, followed many of them, and chosen to “think some more” about others. I’ve also received numerous comments and suggestions from students who have been assigned the book; many of the changes come from them.

General Changes

- Revised the use of *gender* and *sex* for rigor and consistency
- Dropped the box series, “Keeping Humanity in Focus,” although I worked most of the

examples into the text

- Updated GSS and other data where available and appropriate
- C-O-L-O-R!

Specific Changes

Chapter One

- Discussed the distinction between *sex* and *gender*, explaining how the terms will be used throughout this book
- Added a discussion of the Arbesman’s Half-Life of Facts
- Added a discussion of probabilistic causation in the section on determinism and agency

Chapter Two

- Have added bibliographic citations for classic works, such as Comte and Darwin
- Revised the introduction to the section, Traditional Model of Science
- Removed references to Chapter 1 discussion of postmodernism
- Added a discussion of big data
- Added discussion of Karl Popper’s principle of falsifiability
- Expanded the discussion of feminist paradigms

Chapter Three

- Updated the AAPOR Code of Ethics to 2010
- Expanded discussion of National Commission for the Protection of Human Subjects of Biomedical and Behavioral Research
- Added a comment on the need for special care when dealing with vulnerable populations
- Discussed an article about British RECs (aka IRBs) and the special problems faced by qualitative researchers
- Added discussion of confidentiality with visual images
- Added a discussion of fraudulent “research”

Chapter Four

- Referenced Peter Lynn volume on longitudinal studies

- New Research in Real Life box reporting a graduate student's research in North Africa
- New diagram comparing several study types
- Discussion of how social research can combat environmental problems
- Introduced “panel mortality” and cited study using Facebook to track down missing subjects
- More explanation for Figure 4-1
- Updated dates in Figure 4-5
- Added a link from cohort to panel studies
- New section on mixed modes

Chapter Five

- Revised the introduction to sections on Levels of Measurement and Nominal measures
- Augmented discussion of measuring quality of life at colleges
- Deleted discussion of *sex* and *gender*—discussed earlier
- Dropped the Patricia Fisher box on variable names
- Shortened the examples of operationalization
- Added an example of “Cornish” as an ethnic group in some studies

Chapter Six

- Revised the discussion of Public Health ratings of U.S. states
- Added a Research in Real Life box, “Indexing the World”
- Updated GSS data on abortion attitudes
- Expanded the explanation of Guttman scaling

Chapter Seven

- Moved discussion of cell phones and sampling from Chapter 9
- Augmented discussion of cell phones and sampling with Pew Center results
- Updated GSS data to 2012 for Guttman scale example
- Added a discussion of “credibility intervals”
- Introduced the term *chain referral*
- Cited Michael Brick's suggestion of a rebirth of quota sampling
- Revised Tips and Tools box on Using a Table of Random Numbers

- Revised Figure 7-11, referring to new random number appendix
- Streamlined the discussion of sampling frames
- Added discussion of difficulty of sampling for Internet surveys
- Added a section on Factorial Designs
- Added explanation of FCC rules on calling cell phones

Chapter Eight

- Added suggestions by Horne and Lovaglia for using experiments in criminology
- Added suggestions by Schumann for using experiments to pretest survey-question wording

Chapter Nine

- Moved discussion of cell phones and sampling to Chapter 7
- Introduced Mick Couper's Designing Effective Web Surveys
- Added example of qualitative secondary analysis involving gay and lesbian child rearing
- Expanded and updated section on online surveys
- Moved discussion of RDD sampling to Chapter 7
- Added examples for ways of increasing response rates
- Added a section on mixed-mode surveys
- Expanded on the advantages of online surveys

Chapter Ten

- Added discussion of the American/European cultural roots of interviewing
- Discussion of the distinctions between journalistic and social research
- Added a fuller discussion of the role of the literature review in connection with the Grounded Theory Method
- Added caution of picking biased sample of cases

Chapter Eleven

- Added example of climate change and population growth

- Updated census data on education/gender/income
- Discussed Wordscores for analyzing manifest content
- Study analyzing gendered toys offered on Disney website
- Added more-recent study of suicide rates
- Created a new section on Online Unobtrusive Research with a great many examples
- Introduced the Census Bureau's American Community Survey and Census Explorer
- Expanded on the concept of big data

Chapter Twelve

- New Tips and Tools box introducing the concept of Positive Deviance
- New Research in Real Life box discussing social research in China with a special focus on the Canton Public Opinion Research Center
- Expanded the text explanation of Figure 12-2

Chapter Thirteen

- Completely revamped the QDA example, introducing NVivo 9 and Qualrus
- Added another example of understanding quantitative data in a qualitative format (2012 election returns)

Chapter Fourteen

- Clarified the discussion of measures of central tendency
- Added to the discussion of interpreting relationships between two variables
- Moved Sociological Diagnostics to Chapter 15

Chapter Fifteen

- Deleted the tables from *The American Soldier*
- Moved Sociological Diagnostics from Chapter 14
- Related attitudes toward Medicare to attitudes toward Obamacare
- Added new and updated variables to gender/income analysis

Chapter Sixteen

- Introduced Logit and Probit regression models
- Expanded section on GIS, including a graphic example

- Added a discussion of computer packages commonly used for statistical analyses

Chapter Seventeen

- Expanded the discussion of the peer-review process
- Introduced the Digital Object Identifier as an attempt to make web materials available in the long run

As always, I've updated materials throughout the book. As an instructor, I'm constantly searching for new and more-effective ways of explaining social research to my own students; many of those new explanations take the form of diagrams. You'll find several new graphical illustrations in this edition. Once again, I've sought to replace aging research examples (except for the classics) with more-recent ones. I've also dropped some sections that I don't think do much for students anymore.

As with each new edition, I would appreciate any comments you have about how the book can be improved. Its evolution over the past years has reflected countless comments from students and others.

Pedagogical Features

Although students and instructors both have told me that the past editions of this book were effective tools for learning research methods, I have used this revision as an opportunity to review the book from a pedagogical standpoint, fine-tuning some elements, adding others. Here's the package we assembled for the 14th edition.

Chapter Overview Each chapter is preceded with a pithy focus paragraph that highlights the principal content of the chapter.

Chapter Introduction Each chapter opens with an introduction that lays out the main ideas in that chapter and, importantly, relates them to the content of other chapters in the book.

Clear and provocative examples Students often tell me they find the research examples help to clarify difficult and/or abstract ideas, and this edition has many new examples as well as some that have proven particularly valuable in earlier editions.

Exploring the Variety of Random Documents with Different Content



"If I only dared to chuck it."

"Well, why don't you?" Bob asked kindly.

"You don't know that gang or you wouldn't ask. My life wouldn't be worth a plugged cent if I went back on them."

"But suppose I loaned you the money to go back home?"

"I couldn't go back, not yet. If I could make good first then I might have the courage to go back and face father but, as it is now, well, I just couldn't, that's all, but I'm mighty thankful for the offer just the same."

"See here, man, don't you realize that the farther you go with this sort of thing the harder it's going to be to break away. You ought to know that this kind has only one end. They'll get you sooner or later. Be a man and make the break now before the law has anything on you."

Bob spoke sternly and he could see that his words were having an effect on the man.

"Even if they should catch you it would be no worse than what, this sort of thing will lead to," he added in an effort to clinch the argument.

"I'll do it," he said after a moment's hesitation.

"Yes, yer will, not."

At the words a large, red-haired man stepped out from behind a tree.

CHAPTER VIII.

THE RAID.

Bob knew at once that it was Red Hains and his hand moved toward his pocket.

"Keep yer hand away from that pocket if yer want to live any longer," Hains snapped.

Bob knew that, although the man had nothing in his hands, he was reputed to be a streak of lightning when it came to getting a gun out, so he prudently did as he was ordered.

"That's better, an' see that yer keep 'em away." Then turning to the other he snapped: "Wall, yer poor snivling apology of a half-baked man, what yer got ter say fer yerself?"

"Nothing," Royce replied sullenly.

"Nothin', eh. Do yer know I've half a mind ter put a hunk o' lead in yer, right now?"

"Go ahead, if it'll do you any good," Royce retorted.

"Yer think I'm bluffing, eh. Then take this."

As he spoke the man's hand moved with the quickness of a flash toward his belt, but before the gun was out a deep voice boomed out:

"Hands up, Red. I gotta bead on yer an' I'll drill yer if yer move."

At the first word Hains' hand had stopped and before the command was finished they were elevated above his head. Then Slats Magee stepped into view.

"Real nice social little party we got here," he said keeping his gun trained on Hains. "An' will yer look at who's here?" he added motioning with his head to Hains.

"Gee, but I'm glad to see you, Slats," Bob cried.

"An' I'm glad ter get ter the party on time," Slats grinned.

At that instant the sound of a shot far off in the forest made them turn their heads and when they turned them back Red Hains was gone.

"What the——" Slats began and then stopped short. "Now, what do yer know about that?" he finished sheepishly. "Whar did that skunk get to?"

"How could a man disappear as quickly as that?" Bob gasped.

"Well, I reckon mebbe it's good riddance ter bad rubbish, as the sayin' is. We'd a had a sweet time gettin' of him in. But who's this feller?"

"In a few words Bob told him Royce's story and the sympathies of the man were at once engaged.

"Sure, we'll look out for him. Don't yer fret, young feller. If yer want ter go straight, you're goin' ter get a chance an' don't yer fergit it. But I plumb fergot sumpin'." And he pulled out his gun and fired three shots in rapid succession into the air.

"The boys been out huntin' fer yer all night and that's the signal if yer was found," he explained.

"It's too bad," Bob told him. "I ought to have known better than to have attempted it. But how far am I from the trail?"

"'Bout five miles, mebbe a little more."

"So far as that?"

"Yep, and I reckon we'd better be makin' tracks. My horse is 'bout two miles back. Couldn't get him any further."

They started at once, Slats leading and the others following close at his heels.

"How did you know where to find me?" Bob asked after they had covered perhaps a mile.

"Didn't know. Jest went it blind."

"Well, I never was more glad to see anyone."

"Reckon not."

Soon they reached the place where Slats had left his horse and he insisted on Bob riding. But he refused as did Royce and the argument ended with them all going on foot, Slats leading the animal. It was about ten o'clock when they struck the trail not far from where Bob had left his horse.

"You wait here till I get Satan," Bob said as he turned down the trail.

But when he reached the place, a few minutes later, there was no horse to welcome him.

"He's either broken away or someone has stolen him," he thought as he examined the place where he had tied him.

The ground was considerably tramped up and the tree, to which he had been tied had been gnawed, but there was nothing to indicate which of his guesses was correct.

When he got back to where he had left the others he found that Sue, Jack and three of the boys had joined them.

"Didn't I tell you that you'd get caught?" Sue demanded as soon as he came in sight.

"Indeed, you did, and if I hadn't been a fool I'd have followed your advice. But never again," and he held up his hand as if taking an oath.

Royce's presence had been already explained and, after again firing the signal, they started for the ranch, two of the horses carrying double.

"I wouldn't care so much if I had accomplished anything," Bob confided to Jack behind whom he was riding.

"I should say you had accomplished a whole lot," Jack retorted.

"What do you mean? We know no more now than before."

"But how about Royce?"

"If he goes straight from now on I'll say that you did more than if you had caught the whole gang."

"Maybe you are right."

"I know I am."

They reached the ranch in time for dinner and found that Jeb and one of the others had returned having heard the first signal and, at the time, having been nearer home.

"I'll bet I could eat a raw moccasin," Bob declared a few minutes later as they sat down at the table.

They had just started to eat when one of the men came in and announced that Satan had just come in by himself.

By the time they had finished the meal all the boys were back and Bob had to repeat his story several times. All were greatly interested in young Royce and he was almost overcome by the kindness shown him declaring over and over again that he did not deserve it. Jeb added his advice to that which Bob had given him, that he take money and go back home. But he said that he would do anything else that they wished but that he could not do.

"You don't know my father," he told them. "Oh, he's a good father and all that but he is absolutely merciless when it comes to a thing like this. He'd have me arrested and put me in jail in a minute if I went back to him like this. I know I deserve it and if it wasn't for mother I'd be willing to face him and take what was coming, but it would kill her."

Tears had been gathering in the man's eyes while he was talking and by the time he had finished he was sobbing in good earnest.

"There, there, son, we all make mistakes and you shall have a chance right here to make good," Jeb assured him, laying a kindly hand on his

shoulder.

"You're better to me than I deserve, sir," he sobbed, "but if you'll only give me a chance I'll try so hard."

"Then it's settled. You are on the payroll of the Lazy S."

"But you must not pay me anything, at least until I'm worth it."

"Well, we won't fight over that," Jeb told him kindly.

"It is something that I'll never forget and I'll make good."

"Of course, you will."

It developed that Royce knew nothing more about Red Hains and his gang than he had already told them. He had never been to their rendezvous and had no idea where it was.

"I don't think Hains trusted me fully," he told them, "and he, as well as the others, were careful not to talk about their business when I was around. Guess I was kind of on probation."

"But did you never hear him say anything about this ranch?" Jeb asked him.

"No, sir, I——. Yes, I did, too. It was last night, just before we camped. I was tending to the horses and he and one of the men were talking only a few feet away and I heard him say that the Lazy S had the best bunch of cattle in the country but that they were pretty well guarded and it would be pretty risky to try to run any of them off."

"Then you don't know whether he intends to try it or not?"

"No, sir, that was all I heard him say. They moved away then and I didn't hear anything more."

"Well, you'd better stick pretty close to the ranch for a while. I fancy it would go pretty hard with you if he should get hold of you again."

"He'd kill me."

"Probably he would."

The herd of the Lazy S was grazing on what was called the lower range, about two miles from the house. Jeb called all the boys for a consultation before supper and arranged that they should guard them in two shifts, each being on duty from six to six.

"There's little doubt in my mind but what he'll have a try at 'em sooner or later," Jeb told them. "He may get away with it, but we'll make it as hard for him as we can, eh."

"Sure, an' we'll do that," Grumpy declared, and all the others were just as enthusiastic.

"The finest and most loyal bunch of men I ever had," Jeb told the boys as the men left the porch.

"Which shift do we go with?" Bob asked.

"Why, you——"

"Sure, we're going to help. We wouldn't miss it for the world," Jack broke in. Jeb insisted that he was responsible for them and that there was too much risk attached to it, but they finally won a reluctant consent to join the day shift.

It was sometime in the night when Bob suddenly awoke. He was aware that he had heard something, but what it was he did not know, but a moment later; he heard it again and this time he knew that it was a shot and it came from the south. Almost at the same time he heard someone moving in the kitchen out of which their room opened. He gave Jack a sharp nudge.

"Wake up, there," he whispered in his ear.

"What's the idea," Jack grunted sleepily.

"Something's doing. Come, snap out of it," he ordered, slipping from the bed and dragging Jack after him.

"Have a heart," Jack groaned as he bumped his head on the floor.

"Sorry, but we've got to make it snappy."

As they pulled on their clothes they could hear Jeb's voice out on the porch shouting to the men.

"Think it's a raid?" Jack asked.

"What do you suppose it is?" Bob retorted. "Think they're indulging in target practice?"

"Not exactly, but——"

"Stop talking and get a hustle on," Bob ordered as he pulled open the door and stepped out of the room.

There was no one in the kitchen and he rushed out on to the porch where he bumped into Jeb who was about to come in.

"Is it Hains?" he asked.

"No doubt of it, I guess, but you boys keep out of it."

"But we want to go."

"Too risky."

"But we'll be careful and——"

But Jeb did not wait to hear any more for at that moment the men came up with the horses and he rushed into the house to come out again almost immediately buckling his gun-belt about his waist, Jack was close behind him, buttoning up his shirt on the way.

Bob made one more effort

"Please let us go," he pleaded, catching hold of Jeb's arm.

"Who's that can't go?"

The one who asked the question was Sue and she was dressed in her riding suit and her small automatic was strapped about her slim waist.

"Nothing doing, this time, Sue," Jeb put all the command possible into the order.

"But——"

"No buts about it. This is no business for a girl."

"But——"

"Oh, well, I can't stop to argue any more. Come along, if you must, but you must stay well behind. Make it snappy, now, every minute counts."

The two boys took it for granted that the permission included them and followed Sue's flying feet to the corral. They were mounted and back with the others almost in no time.

"You keep well in the rear," Jeb cried as he gave the order to start, and he swept out of the gate closely followed by the rest.

In all, not more than ten minutes has passed since Bob heard the first shot and during that time several more shots had been heard. The night was dark, the new moon having set several hours before, and they could barely see each other as they rode. The shots were coming more frequently now and the pace set by Jeb was a fast one. But Bob was obliged to hold Satan in in order to keep behind the men, as he seemed imbued with the excitement.

"Fire into the air, boys, an' let 'em know we're coming," Jeb shouted a few minutes after they had started and the next moment the air was rent with shots as the order was obeyed.

On through the night they swept the hoofs of the horses hardly seeming to touch the ground so swiftly were they running. A few minutes and they could hear the bellowing of the cattle as they milled this way and that not frightened enough to stampede but very restless.

In another minute Jeb called a halt and ordered the men to stay where they were while he went on to find out the condition of things.

"If I fire two shots close together and then two more after about ten seconds you come a-running, all except you, Sue, and the boys. You three stay where you are and if I shoot twice more quick-like, you beat it for the house. You can tell my gun from the rest."

As he spoke he melted into the darkness and they waited. Minute after minute passed and they were all getting impatient when the signal came.

"Come on, boys, whoop her up," one of the men shouted, and the three were alone.

"Gee, but I wish he hadn't told us not to go any farther," Jack declared.

"Same here, but I reckon he knows best," Bob said, stroking Satan's neck in an effort to quiet him.

"I can usually wheedle father into most anything, but when he speaks like that I know better than to disobey. I tried it just once and that was a-plenty."

"Of course, we wouldn't think of not doing as he ordered," Jack told her.

No shots had been heard since the men rode off and they were beginning to wonder if it was all over when two shots rang out close together.

"That's dad's old Betsey and it means for us to beat it," Sue said as she turned her horse. "Come on and come a-running."

She took the lead and the boys followed. If they had come out fast it seemed as though they were flying now, and the lights of the ranch house loomed up almost, it seemed, before they were fairly started. Then, when

they were about a hundred yards from the house when Sue stopped so suddenly that Jack had all he could do to keep from running into her.

"Look," she gasped.

One glance was enough. At one corner of the big barn a thin blaze of light gleamed through the darkness.

"They've fired the barn," Bob cried. "Come on, Jack, we must put it out if possible."

"Just a minute," Sue called as he was about to start. "We don't know how many of them there may be and we must be careful."

"But listen——" Bob began, but Sue interrupted.

"You got your guns with you?"

"Sure."

"Then we'll ride on firing as fast as we can, and they may think that the whole outfit is coming."

"Good plan," Bob agreed. "Come on."

He led and they rode rapidly directly for the barn shooting and yelling at the top of their voices. No shots answered theirs and they reached the barn without seeing anyone. The lower part of the corner was blazing fiercely and it looked as though the barn would surely go. But all three were determined that it should not if they could prevent it. Fortunately there was a pump only a few yards away, and Bob shouted as he threw himself from his horse:

"See if there's a bucket at the well, Jack."

Then he ran for the house where he knew he would find several. He knew that the barn was filled with dry hay and if the fire once got to it there would be no chance of saving it. He was back almost immediately with two

buckets to find Jack pumping furiously into an old leaky pail. Throwing down the empty ones he grabbed the other shouting:

"You and Sue keep 'em filled."

A good part of the water leaked out before he could get to the barn and what was left seemed to have no effect at all and, throwing the pail aside, he rushed back for another. This one was filled by the time he grabbed it and when he had dashed the contents on the fire he was a little encouraged. Back and forth he ran, but the fire persisted in eating its way into the dry timber and he feared that it was gaining on him. He had made over twenty trips and was about exhausted when, as he came back for another pailful, Jack shouted:

"Change places with me, Bob. You're about puffed."

Jack was comparatively fresh as Sue had been doing a part of the pumping and by the time he had made a dozen trips back and forth the fire was well under control.

"A couple more pailfull and she'll be out," he panted.

"My, but it's lucky we got here just when we did," Sue declared a few minutes later as, the fight ended, they stood looking at the blackened timbers. "If it had got a bit more of a start it would have gone up sure as smoke."

"And in smoke," Jack laughed.

"What'll we do now?" Bob asked after a moment's silence.

"Have you heard any shooting since we got here?" Sue asked.

"No, but I reckon that doesn't mean that there hasn't been any. We've been so busy that I guess we wouldn't have heard it if a gattling gun had been in action out there."

"Listen a moment," Sue suggested.

But not a sound came to them and Sue soon declared that the raid must be over.

"I hope they didn't get away with any of the cattle," she added.

"What do you suppose they set fire to the barn for?" Jack asked.

"Oh, I imagine they were getting the worst of it and sent a couple of the men to fire the barn hoping that our men would see the fire and rush to put it out. Then they'd have the cattle to themselves. Or perhaps they just did it out of pure spite. They're bad enough to do anything."

"Had we better ride back?" Bob asked.

"I don't think so. The scrap must be over or we'd hear firing. No, I think we better go up to the house and wait till they come back."

"All right," Bob agreed. "But I'm going to take a look around first. You and Jack go up to the house and I'll be there in a few minutes."

"Yes, you will, not," Jack said quickly. "We'd have to spend the rest of the night and all day tomorrow hunting for you."

"Nonsense."

"No nonsense about it," Sue broke in. "If any of them are lurking around here they'd be sure to see you first and get the drop on you before you could do a thing. No, we'll all go to the house and sit tight till the boys get back. We can keep an eye on the barn, but I hardly think they'll try it again."

Bob, knowing that he had come to grief once through not taking Sue's advice, did not insist further, although he felt that it was a risky thing to leave the barn unprotected. They found the horses where they had left them and turned them into the corral after taking off the saddles, and then returned to the house. They had still heard no shot and Sue declared that some of them, at least, ought to be getting back.

"That is, if they aren't off chasing them," she added.

"Do you think they'd do that while it is so dark?" Jack asked.

"Goodness, I don't know. There's no accounting for what that dad of mine will do once he gets started."

"Well, it'll begin to get light in a half-hour or so," Bob told them glancing at his watch.

The coming dawn was just beginning to lift the darkness when they heard the beating of hoofs.

"There're coming," Sue cried, leading the way to the porch, and in about ten minutes Jeb and two of the men swung themselves from their dripping horses.

"You all safe?" was his first question.

"Right side up and a yard wide," Sue replied.

"Good. They got young Royce."

"Bad?" Sue's voice disclosed her anxiety.

"Just below the shoulder. I don't think it went through the lung, but I'm not sure."

"Where is he?"

"Down by the spring. I thought it best not to try to bring him in on horseback, so we came in for the buckboard. Slim is with him and he ain't bleeding nothing to speak of."

"But the rustlers?" Sue asked.

"They got away with about twenty-five head, I reckon. Had 'em cut out before we got there."

"But couldn't you follow them?" Bob asked.

"Sure, we did as far as the woods. You see," he went on to explain, "we knew it would be plum suicide to follow them into the forest."

"Why?" Jack asked as he paused.

"Because the man who is being followed always has the big advantage in the darkness, as he pretty well knows where the other fellow is and all he has to do is to wait for him to get up close enough and then pot him, and I don't risk human life for a few cattle. But, believe me, we ain't done with that gang, not by a long shot."

Bob was about to ask another question, but just then the two men, who had returned with Jeb, drove up with the buckboard.

"Get a bed ready and we'll be back in about half an hour," Jeb said as they drove off.

"Oh, I do hope that he isn't badly hurt," Sue said as she turned back to re-enter the house. "It would be too awful if he should die before he has a chance to make good."

"Isn't there a doctor anywhere near here?" Bob asked as he followed her in.

"Not nearer than Cold Springs. His name is Lawton. Suppose you try to get him on the phone while I get the bed ready. He has a flivver and ought to get here in a couple of hours if he's at home."

Bob got the number after what seemed a long time and, to his great relief, the doctor was at home and promised to get there as fast as his car would bring him. Meantime Jack had built a fire and put on water to heat and, after that there was nothing to do except wait for them to bring the wounded man in.

It was not long, however, before they heard the sound of wheels and they had hardly more than gotten on to the porch when the buckboard turned in at the gafe. Royce looked very white as they lifted him carefully from the seat where Jeb had been holding him.

"Is he dead?" Sue gasped as she caught sight of his white face.

"Only fainted," her father assured her.

Carefully they placed the wounded man on the bed and Sue hastened to fetch a basin of cold water, and, under her skilled ministrations, he soon opened his eyes with a deep sigh.

"Don't try to speak," Sue ordered, laying her cool hand on his brow.

The youth smiled weakly and closed his eyes.

"Get me the hot water," she whispered to Bob.

"Sue's about as good as a doctor," Jeb told him as he turned to obey. "But I ought to have told you to call Lawton."

"I did, sir, and he's coming as soon as possible," Bob replied.

"That's good. That man knows his business."

Bob was back with the water in less than a minute and, ordering them all out of the room, the girl set to work.

"He's asleep, now, and I think he'll pull through," she told the boys when she joined them on the porch a half-hour later, "I'm pretty sure the bullet just missed the lung and it went right through, making a clean wound."

"That's fine," Bob rejoiced. "You know, I believe that there's a lot of good in him only he's evidently weak."

"And he'll have you to thank if he makes good," Jack declared.

Before Bob had time to say anything Charlie came to the door to tell them that breakfast was ready and they lost no time in obeying the summons.

"How came you fired those two shots for us to beat it back, dad?" Sue asked as soon as they were seated.

"I didn't."

"But we heard them."

"Must be some other gun sounds like Betsey, then."

"But it's funny you didn't hear them."

"Maybe I was too excited," Jeb grinned.

"Well, it's mighty lucky someone fired them."

"How come?"

Then she told him about the fire and what a time they had had to put it out.

"You're right it was lucky," Jeb assured them when she had finished. "It would have hit us mighty hard if that barn had gone up. It would have made us short on hay for next winter. The skunks. This country's got to get rid of them some way or other."

"How about the sheriff?" Bob asked. "Can't he do anything?"

"Frankly I don't know," Jeb told them. "He's a fellow by the name of Longly, Skeets Longly, they call him, and he does an awful lot of blowing about what he's going to do but, somehow or other, he doesn't seem to get many results. Oh, I know he's up against a hard proposition when he's bucking the Hains gang but, what I say is that if he can't do the job, and it seems he can't, he ought to call on the state troops. I'll bet they'd clean it up but Skeets he can't seem to see it that way, leastwise he hasn't yet."

As soon as breakfast was over Sue hastened to see to her patient and returned almost at once with the news that he was still sleeping and seemed to be doing well.

"Where's the rest of the boys?" she asked as soon as she made her report.

"I told them to stay with the herd," Jeb told her. "Charlie's putting up some grub and one of the boys'll take it out to them."

"You think they'll come back?"

"Can't tell but I'm taking no chances."

About an hour later Dr. Lawton drove noisily into the yard, the radiator of his little car steaming like a locomotive. He was a little man, hardly over five feet tall, and probably did not weigh much over a hundred pounds. But what he lacked in size he more than made up for in energy.

"Where's the patient?" he demanded as he jumped out of the car.

"In here, doctor. Follow me," Sue ordered.

They were gone the better part of an hour while Jeb and the two boys anxiously awaited his report on the front porch. Finally they came out.

"Well?" Jeb asked.

"Waste of my time coming way out here," the little doctor growled. "That girl of yours is as good as any doctor."

"Huh, from the time you've taken I thought you must be taking him apart to see what makes the wheels go round."

"Had to do something to earn my fee, but he'll be as fit's a fiddle in a couple of weeks. But if that bullet had gone in half an inch lower down 'twould have been another story. By the way, who is he? Reminds me of a young fellow I've seen hanging around the hotel in town."

"Guess likely he's the fellow," Jeb said and told him Royce's story.

"Thought I wasn't mistaken," the doctor said when he had finished. "Well, he's fallen into good hands, all right, if he wants to turn over a new leaf and go straight."

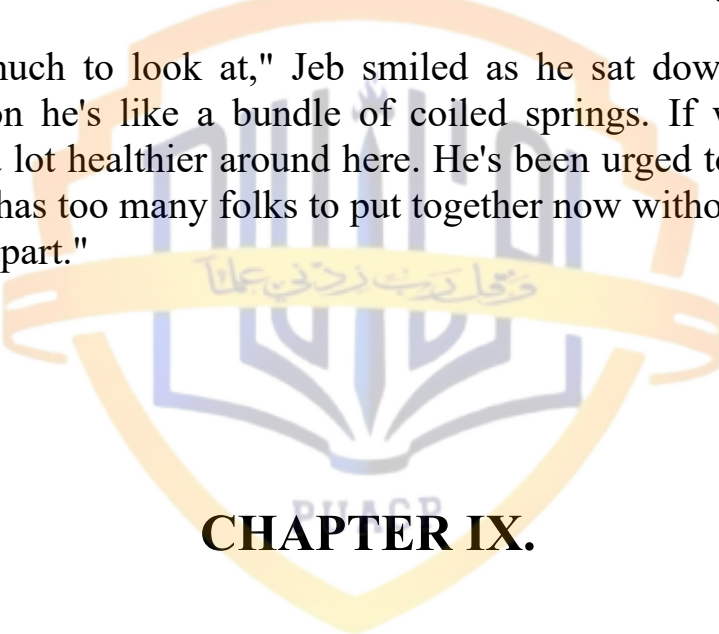
"Oh, I'm sure he does," Sue assured him.

"Well, I hope so, but you never can tell about these fellows you pick up. Well, I must be getting back. Got a lot of work to do. Keep him quiet for a few days and you won't need me again."

"Red Hains got twenty-five or thirty of my cattle last night. That's how he got shot. Tried to capture the whole gang, he did. When you get back to town tell Skeets about it, will you? I don't suppose 'twill do any good, but you tell him just the same," Jeb said as the doctor, after filling the radiator, climbed into the car and started the engine.

"I'll tell him all right and give him a piece of my mind in the bargain," the doctor promised as he turned the car and shot out of the gate.

"He's not much to look at," Jeb smiled as he sat down, "but when it comes to action he's like a bundle of coiled springs. If we had him for sheriff it'd be a lot healthier around here. He's been urged to take the office but he says he has too many folks to put together now without trying to take more of them apart."



CHAPTER IX.

SUSPICIONS.

A week passed and nothing more had been seen or heard of the Hains gang. The boys insisted on being a part of the day shift and from six in the morning until six at night they were out guarding the herd. It was a free open life and they enjoyed every minute of it. Young Royce improved steadily and by the end of the week was able to sit up a part of the time.

Several hours each day, while they were on duty, the boys, under the skillful tutelage of Slim and Slats, practiced throwing the lasso, a sport which they found very fascinating.

"Yer'll shore be experts if yer keep it up much longer," Slat's told them after Bob had just executed a particularly difficult throw over the head of a young bull.

"When I can throw as well as you can I'll be satisfied," Bob told him.

"What, him?" Slim had come up in time to hear Bob's remark. "Shaw, he's no good."

"Who's no good?" Slat's demanded very red in the face.

"You ain't, that is, not with a rope, you ain't."

"Huh, 'f I couldn't beat you two ways o' Sundays the only use I'd make of a rope'd be to hang myself." Slat's retorted.

"Whar'd yer want us ter sent yer remains?" Slim asked gravely.

"Thar ain't goin' ter be any remains not till yer improve a whole lot," Slat's flung at him as he turned away to attend to some duty. "Slim's all right," he continued, turning to the boys, "till he thinks somebody thinks as how he can do sumpin' better nor he can, then he jest has to naturally shoot off his mouth."

"But——"

"Course Slim's a good roper but, laws sakes wouldn't do ter let him know yer thinks so. Why only 'bout a month ago some idjut as ought ter have known better, complimented him on his throwin' an' right away he went an' bought a new hat two sizes larger nor he'd been wearin' an' his old one only six years old come next winter."

It was perhaps an hour later when Slim had a chance to tell his side.

"Yer'd think ter hear that tall shank o' bones talk that he'd invented the art o' ropin'. Why, bless yer heart, I've seen that guy miss more steers nor yer could shake a stick at/ Only time he's sure of catchin' anything's when he's right enough ter lay the loop over 'thout throwin' it 'tall."

Then, as he noticed the look of incredulity on the

"Course I'm only speakin' in comparative terms, so to speak. What I mean is that compared with some he'd measure up fairly well, mebby better nor the average. But 'twouldn't do ter let him think yer think so. He's the greatest feller yer ever saw ter get a big head, Slat's is. Why, 'twont more'n a month ago that he went an' bought a new hat two sizes bigger nor the one he'd been wearing jest because some feller told him a throw he'd made was the best he'd ever seen."

"And I don't suppose his old one was more than six years old," Bob said soberly.

"'Twon't that much, he'd only had it five years come Christmas."

"Can you beat it?" Bob asked a moment later after the cowboy had left them. "And yet, I reckon it would be hard to find two better friends anywhere."

"You said it," Jack agreed. "Why only the other day Slat's gave Grumpy a licking because he said that Slim was too big for his pants."

"They're a funny pair all right, but mighty good fellows when it comes right down to brass tacks. But who's that fellow?" Bob asked pointing toward a horseman who was riding toward them.

"He's not one of our boys, that's sure."

They were, at the time, on the side of the herd nearest the house, all the others being some distance away and the man was approaching from the direction of Cold Springs. As he came nearer they could see that he was middle aged, roughly, even raggedly dressed, and rode a horse which looked as disreputable as himself.

"Hello, boys," he sang out when he was within a few feet of them.

"How do you do?" Bob replied courteously.

"Only middling. What ranch is this here?"

"It's the Lazy S," Bob told him.

"Lazy S, eh. Looks like it had better be called the Busy S," he returned, glancing about. "How's chances on landing a job?"

"You'll have to see Mr. Stebbins," Bob told him.

"Whar is he?"

"He's probably at the house."

"And how far away is it?"

"About two miles," Bob told him.

"Think he wants any more help?"

"Really I couldn't say."

"I heard him say the other day that he'd like one or two more men," Jack volunteered.

"That's good news cause I sure do need one. Which way is the house?"

"That way," Bob replied pointing. "You'll see it as soon as you get over that rise."

"Then I go see him. Did you say he name is Steblits?"

"Stebbins," Jack corrected him.

"Stebbins. I'll try to remember it," the man said as he turned his horse and, with a parting wave of his hand, rode off.

"He looks as though he might have seen better days," Jack said when he was out of hearing.

"Doesn't look as though he could have seen much worse ones," Bob replied and then he remained in deep thought till Jack said:

"A penny for your thoughts."

"I was just thinking that I've seen that man before."

"You have? Where?"

"That's what I was trying to remember."

"Well, don't let me interrupt."

For several moments Bob did not speak. Something in the man's voice rather than his looks had awakened the memory of a few days past. Once again he was sitting on a log watching a group of men as they sat about a fire playing cards.

"I have it," he finally burst out. "That man belongs to Red Hains' gang."

"What?"

"You heard what I said."

"But are you sure?"

"Almost. You see, I didn't get a very good look at all of them but I remember that voice."

"But what's he doing here?"

"We could only guess at that but, taking it for granted that I'm right, what would you guess?"

"That he's a spy, of course."

"That may be. Yes, you're probably right but my guess is that he's spying after Royce."

"You mean—?"

"I mean that if he's the man I think he is, I believe Hains has sent him here to do some harm to Royce."

"What'll we do about it?"

"We ought to warn Jeb before he hires him, but I don't see how we can do it."

"Nor I. We couldn't possibly get to the house ahead of him without him seeing us."

"I have it," Bob said a moment later.

"What's your plan?"

"I'll go catch up with him and make some excuse for going to the house, and maybe I'll get a chance for a word with Jeb before he sees him. If he's all right he can't object and if he isn't we should worry."

"Good enough, but keep an eye on him. If he's what you suspect he'll be suspicious. Don't let him get the drop on you," Jack cautioned as Bob mounted his horse.

"I'll be careful," he called back.

The stranger's horse was fully as slow as his appearance indicated and it was but a few minutes when Satan drew up alongside him. The man glanced at Bob interrogatively but did not appear either displeased or surprised.

"Just thought of something I had to go to the house for," Bob told him.

"That's fine. I like company. Yer see I'm a social critter, I am."

But he did not seem inclined to talk much as they jogged along, although he answered pleasantly enough whenever Bob spoke to him. To Bob's disappointment Jeb came onto the porch as they rode through the gate. He had hoped to be able to tell him what he knew about the man before they met but now that was impossible.

"That Stebbins?" the man asked

"Yes, that's he."

Bob noticed that Jeb was looking at the stranger rather closely as he slipped from his horse and advanced to meet him.

"The boy said as how you needed another hand," he began resting one foot on the lower step.

"Well, I don't know. Guess maybe, I could use another man."

"Then I'm your best bet. I kin do most anythin' from roping ter cooking."

"What's your handle?"

"Most folks call me Los Varney."

"I thought so but wasn't quite sure," Jeb cried holding out his hand. "Don't you remember me?"

"Blast my eyes if it ain't old Jeb," the man almost shouted grasping the outstretched hand. "The boy said as how yer name was Stebbins but I didn't connect up with yer. Thought yer'd gone East and it must be all of fifteen year since we was up in the Bad Lands."

"It's nearer twenty," Jeb told him still shaking his hand.

"Mebby so, mebbly so. Time sure gets away fast when yer get along in years, don't it?"

"It sure does," Jeb agreed. "But how's the world been using you?"

"Oh, 'bout good's I deserve, I reckon. Yer know I never could keep a hold on any coin an' jest now well, I sure need a job."

"Well, you've got one," Jeb assured him. "Turn your nag into the corral and then come and get a bite, that is if you're hungry."

"Ever remember seein' me when I wasn't?" the man grinned.

Bob had stood by while the two men were talking, his astonishment growing with every sentence. Was it possible that he was mistaken? It would seem so but he knew that he had an almost uncanny memory of voices and he was not at all satisfied even though Jeb had recognized in the man an old friend. Should he tell Jeb what he suspected or would it be better to wait developments? Perhaps it would be the better plan to speak to Royce first and let him have a chance to recognize the man if he had been a member of the gang. Yes, that was the best plan, he decided and, throwing the reins over Satan's head, he entered the house.

He found Royce in the big living room sitting by the window. He looked as Bob entered the room.

"Hello, Bob. In early aren't you?" he greeted him.

"A little. I want to ask you something."

"All right, shoot."

"Was there a man by the name of Los Varney in Hains' gang?"

"Los Varney? Let me see. No, I think not, leastwise I don't remember the name."

"You're sure?"

"Yep. That's not a name to forget very easily, but, of course, I suppose most of them went by assumed names and he might have been calling himself something else. But what's the idea?"

Bob told him about the man who had applied for a job and his suspicions concerning him.

"But you say Jeb knows him?" he asked as soon as he had finished.

"Yes, he knows him all right. In fact it seems that they're old friends or, at least, used to be."

"Then I guess that settles it."

"Not necessarily. You see, it's been twenty years or so since they have seen each other and I reckon a man go bad in less time than that."

"Well, that's right too," and Bob noticed that a pained look crossed the other's face.

"I didn't mean—" he began, but Royce interrupted.

"I know you didn't. What kind of a looking fellow is he?"

"About average height, around forty-five, smooth shaved, or rather he was perhaps four or five days ago. Has a rather high forehead and brown hair. That's about as well as I can describe him."

"But that description would fit half the members of the gang," Royce smiled.

"I know it but it's the best I can do. You see, he hasn't any outstanding characteristics which make him easy to describe. I reckon we'll have to wait till you see him."

The opportunity came about a half hour later when the man came into the room with Jeb.

"You've met Bob here," Jeb said. "And this is Royce. He's got nicked a few days ago in a rumpus we had with the Hains gang."

Bob watched the man closely as he stepped forward and held out his hand to Royce.

"Glad ter meet yer, son," he said.

"Thanks. I'm glad to know any friend of Mr. Stebbins," Royce said easily.

Bob could see that he was scanning the man's face closely but, to his surprise, there was no look of recognition in his eyes. Jeb and Varney soon

went out and the two were alone again.

"Well?" Bob asked.

"Nothing doing. Never saw the man before."

"You're sure?"

"Reasonably. Of course, he may have worn a beard and has shaved it off. That probably would change his looks enough so that I wouldn't recognize him. You know, I was only with them a couple of days and, of course, didn't get to know any of them very well."

"Well, if he's what I thought, he's one peach of an actor," Bob declared.

It was not until after supper was over that Bob had a chance to tell Jack what had happened. He knew by the looks on his brother's face that he was crazy to learn how the man had succeeded in getting into the good graces of Jeb.

"What's the idea?" he asked as soon as he got Bob alone out by the corral. Bob told him what had happened and he gave a low whistle.

"So you missed it that time?"

"I'm not so certain of that," Bob replied.

"But if he's a friend of Jeb."

"That's what Royce said, but, after all, that doesn't prove anything. I tell you, Jack, that man was playing cards by that fire the night they had me caught. I know it but, of course, it's another thing to prove it."

"Did you tell Jeb?"

"Not yet. Think I better?"

"Of course. What's the use in taking chances?"

"I suppose you're right, but I bet he'll laugh at the idea. Remember, all I've got to go on is his voice."

It happened that Jeb joined them at that moment and Bob told him all about it. Jeb's face was very thoughtful while he was telling the story and when he had finished, he said:

"I think you must be mistaken, Bob, but I'm glad you told me. There's no doubt that he's Los Varney all right, but it's not at all impossible that you may be right. It's a long time ago that I knew him and we were together for a year or more, but I've lost track of him since then and he may have gone wrong although, frankly, I don't think so. However we'll keep an eye open and 'forewarned is forearmed' you know."

"He didn't laugh anyhow," Jack declared as soon as they were alone again.

Three days went by. Los Varney proved that he had made no idle boast when he had said that he could do most anything. The man was a splendid rider and roper, and a good mixer with the boys who seemed to like him from the very first. Bob could not see that he displayed any more interest in Royce than was perfectly natural for one of his make up. He seemed naturally sympathetic and appeared anxious to cheer the boy up whenever occasion offered. But that was all.

But there was one member of the household who did not like Los Varney.

"He's a snake in the grass," Sue told Bob before Los had been with them a day.

"What makes you say that?" Bob asked her.

"How do I know. I just know it, that's all," she retorted.

"Intuition?"

"Maybe."

And then Bob told her what he suspected and why.

"I knew it," she declared, her eyes flashing fire, as soon as he had finished.

"Then you think I'm right?"

"Of course, you're right. Didn't I tell you he's crooked?"

"But how can I prove it?"

"You can't. That is you can't till something happens but, you take my word for it, something'll happen before many days go by. Those fellows are short on patience and don't wait long. You'll see."

It was two nights later when something happened which proved to Bob, at least, that both Sue and he were right in their judgment of Los Varney. He woke up sometime during the night and, for some reason which he could not fathom, was unable to go to sleep again. He turned first on one side and then on the other, but it was no use. He was not conscious that he had heard anything or that anything had awakened him. Finally he determined to get a drink of water and slipped quietly from the bed careful not to disturb his brother.

In the kitchen he found the pail empty and, knowing that he would probably wake the whole family if he used the pump, he determined to go out to the pump near the barn. The night was very warm and he did not fear taking cold even though he was clad only in his pajamas. He had gotten his drink and was about to start back when something down by the corral caught his eye. It was bright moonlight and he could see for a long distance.

"Wonder what that is," he thought.

Then he quickly slipped behind a tree, for he had seen that it was a man. The distance was too great for him to be able to identify him but he did note that it was a man of average height. For some moments the man stood perfectly still and, happening to raise his eyes, Bob saw far out on the prairie the flash of light. Three times it flashed and then stopped. Then he